

ESSENTIAL CONVERSATIONS FOR

DIVORCE & MONEY

A guide to protecting your financial future
through the conversations that matter most

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A PERSONAL NOTE

If you're reading this because your relationship is ending, I'm sorry.

I've been through divorce myself, and I know it can feel overwhelming. There are days when simply getting through the next conversation feels like enough.

What I've learned - both personally and through years of helping people navigate difficult money conversations - is that healing doesn't happen overnight. Neither does rebuilding your financial confidence.

Give yourself permission to recover. You don't have to solve every financial problem this week or have all the answers immediately. Some decisions need to be made quickly, but many don't. Take the time to understand your options, ask questions, and seek advice from people you trust.

Divorce marks the end of one chapter, but it doesn't define the rest of your story. With time, support and good decisions, you can build a future that feels secure, hopeful and entirely your own.

One conversation at a time. One decision at a time. One step at a time.

All the best,

A handwritten signature in blue ink that reads "Vanessa Stoykov". The script is fluid and cursive, with the first name "Vanessa" and last name "Stoykov" clearly legible.

BEFORE YOU LEAVE - KNOW WHERE YOU STAND FINANCIALLY

"The strongest position you can be in before separation isn't having more money - it's having more knowledge."

One of the biggest mistakes people make before separation is focusing entirely on the emotional side of leaving and almost none of the financial side. That's understandable.

Divorce is rarely something you've planned for, and emotions can cloud even the most practical decisions.

But this is exactly when understanding your financial position becomes one of the greatest gifts you can give yourself.

I've spoken to many people who reached separation only to realise they didn't know where the family money was held, how much debt existed, what insurance policies were in place or even how much they spent each month just to keep the household running.

That uncertainty creates unnecessary stress at a time when life already feels uncertain.

Being financially informed isn't about hiding money, preparing for a fight or assuming the worst. It's about ensuring you understand your own financial life so you can make thoughtful, informed decisions.

Sarah's Story

Sarah had been married for 18 years.

Her husband looked after almost everything to do with money. He paid the bills, managed the mortgage, dealt with their accountant and handled the investments. Sarah trusted him completely and had never felt the need to become involved.

When they separated, she suddenly found herself needing to make decisions about property, superannuation and debt without knowing exactly what they owned.

She spent weeks searching for paperwork, trying to remember passwords and asking questions she wished she'd asked years earlier.

Looking back, Sarah says the hardest part wasn't dividing the assets - it was feeling completely unprepared.

Why This Conversation Matters

Whether you've been together for five years or thirty, both people should understand the family's financial position.

Before any major decisions are made, try to gather information about:

- Bank accounts
- Savings
- Home loans
- Credit cards
- Personal loans
- Superannuation balances
- Investments and shares
- Business interests
- Insurance policies
- Monthly household expenses
- Income from all sources

If your relationship is respectful, this may simply involve sitting down together and reviewing your finances.

If communication has broken down, gathering copies of your own financial records and understanding your personal financial position becomes even more important.

Don't Forget Your Super

Many Australians underestimate how significant their superannuation balance has become.

For some couples, super can be one of the largest assets they own after the family home.

Understanding its value early allows you to ask better questions when seeking legal and financial advice.

Create Your Own Financial Snapshot

Before making any decisions, write down:

What you own.

What you owe.

What comes into your household each month.

What goes out each month.

What your life might realistically cost on one income.

This exercise isn't about creating fear. It's about replacing uncertainty with clarity.

Vanessa's Conversation Starter

Ask yourself:

"If I needed to explain my financial position to someone tomorrow, could I?"

If the answer is no, that's where to begin.

TAKE ACTION

- Download copies of recent bank statements.
- Check your superannuation balance.
- List every debt in your name or jointly held.
- Make a note of your regular household expenses.
- Create a secure folder for important financial documents.
- Write down questions you want to ask your lawyer or financial adviser.

VANESSA'S INSIGHT

Knowledge is one of the few things nobody can take away from you.

You don't need to become a financial expert overnight. You simply need enough understanding to make informed decisions about your future.

The more prepared you are before major conversations begin, the more confident you'll feel throughout the process.

THE FAMILY HOME - THE BIGGEST EMOTIONAL DECISION YOU'LL MAKE

"Sometimes the home you fought so hard to keep becomes the very thing holding you back."

For many couples, the family home isn't just their biggest financial asset - it's where birthdays were celebrated, children were raised, Christmases were shared and dreams were built.

It's no wonder that deciding what happens to the house can become one of the most emotional parts of any divorce.

Many people tell themselves, "I have to keep the house."

But the better question is often:

"Can I afford to keep the life that comes with it?"

Holding onto the family home can provide stability, particularly when children are involved. But it can also mean taking on a mortgage you can no longer comfortably manage, paying higher insurance and maintenance costs, and sacrificing your long-term financial security.

Sometimes, the bravest decision isn't keeping the house. It's letting it go.

Michelle's Story

Michelle had lived in the same family home for more than 20 years.

When she and her husband separated, she was determined to stay. She wanted the children to finish school in familiar surroundings and couldn't imagine leaving the home where so many memories had been made.

To keep the property, Michelle agreed to take on a much larger mortgage than she could comfortably afford.

At first, it felt like the right decision.

But within two years she was working extra hours just to meet repayments. Maintenance costs kept appearing, interest rates increased and there was little money left to contribute to her retirement savings.

Eventually, Michelle sold the house anyway.

Looking back, she realised she hadn't been fighting for the property.

She had been fighting to keep her old life.

Looking Beyond Today

During divorce it's natural to focus on getting through the next few weeks.

But the decisions you make now may affect the next twenty years.

Ask yourself:

Can I realistically afford the mortgage on one income?

Have I allowed for council rates, insurance and maintenance?

What happens if interest rates rise?

Will I still be able to save for retirement?

Will I have money left for holidays, emergencies or simply enjoying life?

Owning a home should give you security - not constant financial stress.

Remember the Opportunity Cost

Every dollar tied up in a property is a dollar that isn't available elsewhere.

Keeping the family home may mean:

- Less superannuation
- Fewer investments
- Reduced savings
- More debt
- Delaying retirement

Sometimes selling allows both people to start again with greater flexibility and less financial pressure.

There is no universal right answer.

There is only the answer that works best for your circumstances.

Children Don't Need the House - They Need Stability

Many parents worry that selling the family home will damage their children.

Children certainly value familiarity.

But what they value even more is feeling safe, loved and emotionally supported.

A smaller home where you feel financially secure is often healthier than a larger home creating constant financial anxiety.

Your children will remember how you navigated this difficult time far more than the size of the backyard.

Questions to Ask Before Keeping the House

Before making a final decision, ask yourself:

Can I comfortably afford this home on my own?

Am I making this decision emotionally or financially?

What sacrifices will I need to make?

What would my life look like in five years?

What would my retirement look like if I keep this property?

Would selling create more financial freedom?

Sometimes writing the answers down helps separate emotion from reality.

Vanessa's Conversation Starter

Instead of asking:

"How do I keep the house?"

Try asking:

"What housing decision gives me the strongest financial future?"

That subtle shift can completely change the conversation.

TAKE ACTION

- Work out the true monthly cost of owning the home.
- Obtain an up-to-date property valuation.
- Understand the remaining mortgage balance.
- Consider the cost of buying another property if you sell.
- Speak with a mortgage broker before making assumptions about borrowing capacity.
- Think about your retirement, not just the next 12 months.

VANESSA'S INSIGHT

Our homes hold memories, but memories don't live in bricks and mortar.

Some of the happiest people I've met after divorce chose financial freedom over holding onto a house they could no longer comfortably afford.

Your next home may look different.

Your life may look different.

But different doesn't mean worse.

Sometimes letting go of one chapter creates space for an even better one.

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SPLITTING ASSETS - WHAT'S FAIR ISN'T ALWAYS EQUAL

"One of the biggest myths about divorce is that everything is automatically split 50/50. In reality, every family's circumstances are different."

When people first separate, one of the most common questions they ask is:

"Who gets what?"

It's a natural question, but it isn't always the most helpful one.

A better question is:

"What does a fair financial future look like for both of us?"

Dividing assets is rarely as simple as drawing a line down the middle. Every relationship is unique. Some people brought significant assets into the marriage. Others took time out of the workforce to raise children. One partner may have earned more income while the other made non-financial contributions that were just as valuable.

That's why property settlements are based on far more than simply adding up the dollars.

David's Story

David assumed the family home was the only asset worth fighting for.

He agreed to let his former wife keep most of their superannuation because he wanted to walk away with the house.

At the time, it felt like a good outcome.

Ten years later, David still had a mortgage, his home needed expensive repairs and he had far less saved for retirement than he expected.

His former wife, meanwhile, had watched her super continue to grow through investment returns and ongoing contributions.

Looking back, David realised he'd focused on today's emotions instead of tomorrow's financial reality.

The Family Home Is Only One Piece of the Puzzle

Many people think about property first because it's visible.

But your financial life is much bigger than your home.

Other assets may include:

- Superannuation
- Investment properties
- Shares and managed funds
- Savings accounts
- Businesses
- Vehicles
- Collectables
- Trusts
- Cash
- Redundancy payments
- Long service leave
- Bonuses
- Cryptocurrency

Every asset should be understood before decisions are made.

Debt Is Part of the Conversation Too

It's easy to focus on who receives the assets.

But debts are also divided.

These may include:

- Mortgages
- Credit cards
- Personal loans
- Tax debts
- Business debts
- Buy Now Pay Later accounts
- Car loans

Understanding exactly what debt exists is just as important as understanding what assets exist.

Super Is Property Too

One of the biggest surprises for many Australians is learning that superannuation forms part of the overall property pool.

Because it's not money you can immediately spend, it's often overlooked.

That can be a costly mistake.

For many couples, super is the second largest asset after the family home.

Ignoring it today may affect your quality of life decades from now.

Ask yourself:

How much super do we each have?

How much retirement savings will each of us have after settlement?

Does this outcome still seem fair in twenty years?

Think About Tax Before You Agree

Not every asset has the same value once tax is considered.

For example:

- A property that has increased significantly in value may eventually attract capital gains tax
- Shares may also have tax implications when sold
- A business may require specialist valuation

Two assets with the same dollar value today may produce very different outcomes in the future.

Understanding those differences before signing an agreement can help avoid expensive surprises later.

Fair Doesn't Always Mean Equal

Many people become focused on achieving exactly half of everything.

But fairness is about more than percentages.

It may take into account:

- The length of the relationship
- Contributions made by both people
- Future earning capacity
- Caring responsibilities
- Health
- Age
- Financial resources available to each person

That's why every situation is different.

Comparing your settlement with someone else's rarely helps.

Don't Let Anger Make Financial Decisions

During separation it's easy to think:

"I don't care - I just want this over."

Or:

"I'm going to fight for every last dollar."

Neither mindset usually produces the best long-term outcome.

The goal isn't to punish each other.

The goal is to create two financially sustainable futures.

Sometimes that requires compromise.

Sometimes it requires patience.

Almost always, it requires good advice.

Vanessa's Conversation Starter

Ask yourself:

"Am I negotiating for today's emotions, or for the next twenty years of my life?"

The answer can completely change how you approach your settlement.

TAKE ACTION

- Create a complete list of every asset and liability.
- Obtain current values wherever possible.
- Check both superannuation balances.
- Ask about the tax implications of different assets.
- Don't assume all assets are worth the same simply because they have similar dollar values.
- Seek legal and financial advice before agreeing to a settlement.

VANESSA'S INSIGHT

One of the most important lessons I've learned is this:

The settlement itself is only one part of your financial future.

What you do with the assets after divorce - how you budget, invest, save and rebuild - will often have a far greater impact on your long-term financial wellbeing.

Don't focus only on what you're receiving.

Focus on what your life will look like five, ten and twenty years from now.

That's where the real value of good financial decisions is found.

CHILDREN, MONEY AND CO-PARENTING - THE CONVERSATIONS THAT MATTER MOST

"Children don't need to know every detail of your financial settlement. They do need to know they're safe, loved and not responsible for the problems between their parents."

When relationships end, children often become the centre of every decision.

Parents naturally want to protect them.

But in the middle of divorce, money can quietly become another source of conflict.

Who pays for school fees?

What about sporting activities?

Who buys uniforms?

What happens if one parent earns significantly more than the other?

Should children know about child support?

These conversations are rarely easy.

But one principle is worth remembering:

Children should never feel responsible for adult financial decisions.

Emma and Ben's Story

Emma and Ben had two teenage children when they divorced.

Neither wanted to hurt the children, but every conversation about money became an argument.

One parent would say, "Your dad won't pay for your school camp."

The other would reply, "Your mum keeps asking me for more money."

Without meaning to, both parents were inviting the children into financial conversations they were never equipped to handle.

The children became anxious every time money was mentioned.

Eventually, Emma and Ben agreed on one simple rule.

Financial discussions would stay between adults.

The children would never again be asked to take sides.

It didn't solve every disagreement.

But it gave the children something they desperately needed - peace.

Remember What Your Children Hear

Children notice much more than we think.

Even when you believe they're not listening, they're often absorbing every conversation.

- They hear tension
- They hear frustration
- They hear blame

And many children quietly begin blaming themselves.

It's important to remind them:

"This isn't your fault."

"You don't have to fix anything."

"We both love you."

Those simple messages matter more than most parents realise.

School Fees and Activities

One of the biggest sources of conflict after separation is paying for children's expenses.

These may include:

- School fees
- Uniforms
- Excursions
- Sporting activities
- Music lessons
- Medical expenses
- Tutoring
- Technology
- Driving lessons
- University costs

The more clearly these expenses are discussed upfront, the fewer disagreements tend to arise later.

Assumptions create conflict.

Conversations create clarity.

Child Support Is Only Part of the Picture

Many parents assume that child support covers every expense.

In reality, raising children involves hundreds of decisions that go well beyond regular payments.

Rather than asking:

"Who's paying?"

Try asking:

"What's the fairest way for us to support our children together?"

That small shift changes the conversation from conflict to collaboration.

Don't Compete Through Money

Sometimes, after divorce, parents unintentionally compete.

- One buys bigger presents
- The other pays for expensive holidays
- One says yes because they feel guilty
- The other feels pressured to match it

Children don't need parents competing with each other.

They need parents working together.

Consistency is worth far more than expensive gifts.

Talking to Teenagers About Money

Older children will naturally become curious.

They may ask:

"Why are we selling the house?"

"Can we still afford school?"

"Will we have to move?"

Answer honestly.

But only share information that helps them feel secure.

They don't need to know every financial detail.

They need confidence that the adults are managing the situation.

Adult Children Face Different Challenges

If your children are adults, divorce often changes family dynamics in unexpected ways.

They may worry about:

- Future inheritance
- Caring for ageing parents
- Whether they're expected to take sides
- Helping one parent financially
- Family gatherings and celebrations

Remember that adult children are still children when it comes to their parents separating.

They need reassurance too.

Vanessa's Conversation Starter

Ask yourself:

"Is what I'm about to say helping my child feel safe - or asking them to carry an adult burden?"

If it's the second, pause.

Find another adult to have that conversation with instead.

TAKE ACTION

- Keep financial disagreements away from your children.
- Agree on how you'll discuss major expenses.
- Be consistent where possible.
- Avoid criticising your former partner in front of the children.
- Reassure your children that they are loved by both parents.
- Remember that children need emotional security more than financial detail.

VANESSA'S INSIGHT

Some of the most successful co-parents I've met don't always agree.

They still have different opinions.

They still become frustrated.

But they share one goal.

They refuse to let money damage their children's sense of security.

Years from now, your children probably won't remember every financial decision you made.

They will remember how you made them feel.

If they felt safe, supported and loved through one of the biggest changes in their lives, you've given them something far more valuable than money.

LIVING ON ONE INCOME - REBUILDING YOUR FINANCIAL CONFIDENCE

"Divorce often cuts one household into two. The challenge isn't just dividing the money - it's learning to build a new financial life with what you have."

For many people, one of the biggest shocks after separation isn't the legal process or the paperwork.

It's the first month of paying every bill on your own.

The electricity bill that used to disappear from a joint account.

The mortgage repayment.

The rent.

The groceries.

The car registration.

The insurance.

Suddenly, every financial decision feels heavier because you're making it alone.

That can be frightening.

But it can also become one of the most empowering periods of your life.

I've met countless people who tell me that while they never wanted their marriage to end, learning to manage their own money gave them a confidence they never knew they had.

Karen's Story

Karen had been married for 24 years.

Her husband earned the higher income and managed most of the family's finances. Karen worked part-time while raising their children and never really needed to think about budgets or investments.

After the divorce, she was terrified.

She worried constantly about running out of money.

Every unexpected expense felt like a crisis.

Instead of avoiding her finances, Karen decided to spend one afternoon each week understanding them.

She created a simple budget.

She reviewed every subscription.

She refinanced some debt.

She started adding a small amount into savings each payday.

None of those steps were dramatic.

But twelve months later, Karen said something she'd never expected.

"For the first time in my life, I know exactly where my money goes."

That knowledge gave her something far more valuable than a bigger bank balance.

It gave her confidence.

Your Financial Life Has Changed

Trying to recreate your old lifestyle on one income often leads to disappointment.

Instead, give yourself permission to build a new financial life.

This isn't about settling for less.

It's about creating something sustainable.

That may mean:

- Moving to a smaller home
- Selling a second car
- Cooking at home more often
- Delaying major purchases
- Reviewing every recurring expense

These changes aren't signs of failure.

They're signs that you're adapting.

Start With Your Essentials

When money feels overwhelming, simplify it.

Begin by identifying the essentials:

- Housing
- Food
- Utilities
- Insurance
- Transport
- Healthcare

Once those are covered, you can decide what fits comfortably around them.

Knowing your essential monthly expenses gives you clarity and helps reduce financial anxiety.

Every Dollar Needs a Job

One of the easiest ways to regain control is to tell your money where to go before it disappears.

When your income arrives, allocate it deliberately.

- Money for housing
- Money for bills
- Money for groceries
- Money for savings
- Money for enjoying life

A simple plan is often more powerful than a complicated spreadsheet you'll never use.

Don't Forget Your Emergency Fund

Life doesn't stop throwing surprises at you after divorce.

- Cars break down
- Children need braces
- Hot water systems fail

An emergency fund won't stop those things happening.

But it can stop them becoming financial disasters.

Even putting aside a small amount each week builds resilience over time.

Progress matters more than perfection.

Be Kind to Yourself

One mistake I see repeatedly is people judging themselves against the financial life they had before divorce.

Your circumstances have changed.

Your financial plan should change too.

You aren't starting from scratch.

You're starting from experience.

That experience is incredibly valuable.

Small Wins Create Momentum

You don't need to transform your finances overnight.

Instead, celebrate the small victories.

- Paying off a credit card
- Building your first \$1,000 emergency fund
- Going three months without using Buy Now Pay Later
- Understanding your super
- Creating your first budget

Each one builds confidence.

And confidence changes behaviour.

Vanessa's Conversation Starter

Ask yourself:

"What is one financial decision I could make this week that would make life easier for future me?"

Keep the answer simple.

That's where momentum begins.

TAKE ACTION

- Write down your monthly income.
- List your essential expenses.
- Review every subscription and recurring payment.
- Set up an automatic transfer into savings, even if it's only a small amount.
- Create a simple spending plan that reflects your new life.
- Celebrate one financial win every month.

VANESSA'S INSIGHT

Financial confidence doesn't come from having millions of dollars.

It comes from understanding the money you do have.

Divorce may have changed your circumstances.

It hasn't changed your ability to create a secure future.

One good decision leads to another.

Before long, you'll look back and realise you've built a financial life that belongs entirely to you.

RETIREMENT STARTS TODAY - DON'T LET DIVORCE DEFINE YOUR FUTURE

"Divorce may change your retirement plans, but it doesn't have to destroy them."

When you're going through a divorce, retirement can feel like a lifetime away.

You're trying to find somewhere to live.

You're working out a new budget.

You're helping your children adjust.

The idea of life at 65 or 70 feels almost impossible to think about.

But here's what I've learned after years of talking to Australians about money:

The financial decisions you make during divorce can have a bigger impact on your retirement than almost any other decisions you'll make.

That's why retirement isn't something to think about later.

It starts now.

Julie's Story

Julie was 54 when her marriage ended.

Like many women of her generation, she'd stepped away from full-time work while raising children.

Her husband had continued working and contributing to his superannuation.

When they separated, Julie focused almost entirely on the family home.

She assumed there would always be time to rebuild her retirement savings later.

Then she did the numbers.

She realised she had almost ten years less to contribute than she'd imagined.

That moment changed everything.

Instead of ignoring retirement, Julie made it part of every financial decision that followed.

She returned to work full-time, increased her super contributions where she could and adjusted her expectations about retirement.

She didn't retire with exactly the life she'd originally imagined.

But she retired with security, independence and choices.

Superannuation Isn't Just Another Asset

For many Australians, super is the second-largest asset after the family home.

Yet it's often treated as an afterthought during divorce.

Unlike a house or a car, you can't see your super every day.

But one day, it may become your main source of income.

That's why understanding your super balance - and how it fits into your settlement - is so important.

Ask yourself:

How much super do I have?

How much will I realistically need in retirement?

Will this settlement leave me with enough to build my future?

Have I considered how many years I have left to contribute?

Women Face a Different Challenge

One of the realities of divorce is that women often face greater financial pressure later in life.

Many have spent time out of the workforce raising children or caring for family members.

That often means:

Lower super balances.

Fewer years of contributions.

Lower lifetime earnings.

If this is your situation, don't let it discourage you.

Let it motivate you to make retirement part of your financial recovery plan.

Every contribution you make today has years to grow.

Your Retirement Plan May Need to Change

After divorce, it's okay to revisit your expectations.

Perhaps you'll:

Work a little longer.

Downsize earlier.

Reduce debt more aggressively.

Contribute extra to super when possible.

Invest differently.

Changing the plan isn't failure.

It's adapting to a new reality.

Retirement Is About More Than Money

When I ask people what they want in retirement, they rarely start with numbers.

They talk about freedom.

Time with grandchildren.

Travel.

Volunteering.

Feeling secure.

Living without financial stress.

Money is simply the tool that helps create those choices.

That's why protecting your retirement matters.

Rebuilding Takes Time

One of the biggest mistakes people make after divorce is believing they've fallen too far behind.

They think:

"What's the point?"

The point is that every year you delay rebuilding is one less year your money has to grow.

Even modest contributions, made consistently, can make a significant difference over time.

Don't underestimate the power of small, regular steps.

Don't Forget Insurance Inside Your Super

Many Australians don't realise their super fund may also include insurance.

After divorce, review:

Life insurance.

Total and Permanent Disability (TPD) insurance.

Income protection (if applicable).

Ask yourself:

Is the cover still appropriate?

Are the beneficiaries still correct?

Would I make different choices today?

Vanessa's Conversation Starter

Ask yourself:

"When I picture my retirement now, what do I want it to feel like?"

Notice the question isn't:

"How much money do I need?"

It's about the life you're trying to create.

Once you know that, building the financial plan becomes much easier.

TAKE ACTION

- Check your current super balance.
- Review your investment option within your super fund.
- Update your beneficiaries if needed.
- Understand any superannuation arrangements as part of your settlement.
- Consider whether you can increase contributions in the future.
- Think about what retirement success means to you.

VANESSA'S INSIGHT

I've spent more than twenty years helping Australians prepare for retirement.

The people who enjoy retirement the most aren't always the ones with the biggest balances.

They're the people who planned.

Who adapted.

Who kept making good decisions, even after life threw them unexpected challenges.

Divorce changes many things.

It doesn't take away your ability to build wealth from this point forward.

Your retirement story is still being written.

And today's decisions will help shape the chapters that come next.

PROTECT YOURSELF LEGALLY - THE IMPORTANT DETAILS YOU CAN'T AFFORD TO MISS

"One signature on the right document today can save your family enormous stress tomorrow."

By the time your divorce is finalised, most people are emotionally exhausted.

You've negotiated a settlement.

You've organised somewhere to live.

You've adjusted to a new routine.

The last thing you feel like doing is more paperwork.

But this is exactly when some of the most important financial decisions still need to be made.

I've seen people spend months carefully negotiating their divorce, only to discover years later they forgot to update a beneficiary, rewrite their Will or review their insurance.

Those small oversights can have life-changing consequences.

Think of this chapter as tying up the loose ends of one chapter before you begin the next.

Peter's Story

Peter thought everything had been taken care of after his divorce.

The settlement was complete.

The house had been sold.

They'd divided their assets fairly and both had moved on.

Several years later, Peter remarried.

When a close friend asked if he'd updated his Will, he confidently replied, "That was all done during the divorce."

It wasn't.

His former Will was still in place.

His superannuation beneficiary nomination hadn't been updated.

His life insurance still listed his former spouse.

Fortunately, Peter discovered the problem before anything happened.

Many people aren't so lucky.

Your Will Doesn't Automatically Update Itself

One of the first documents you should review after separation is your Will.

Your circumstances have changed.

Your wishes may have changed too.

You may now want to:

Choose a different executor.

Change who receives your assets.

Protect your children's inheritance.

Include new instructions for your estate.

A Will should reflect the life you're living today - not the one you left behind.

Review Your Super Beneficiaries

Many Australians don't realise that their superannuation doesn't automatically form part of their estate.

Your super fund may pay your balance according to your beneficiary nomination.

If that nomination is outdated, the outcome may not reflect your current wishes.

Review:

Who you've nominated.

Whether the nomination is still valid.

When it expires, if applicable.

It's a simple task that can make an enormous difference.

Review Your Insurance

Divorce often changes your financial responsibilities.

Ask yourself:

Do I still need the same level of life insurance?

Do I have adequate income protection?

Have I reviewed my Total and Permanent Disability (TPD) cover?

Are my beneficiaries correct?

Your insurance should protect the life you're building now.

Enduring Power of Attorney and Medical Decisions

Many people appoint their spouse to make financial or medical decisions if something happens to them.

After divorce, ask yourself:

Is this still the person I want making those decisions?

If not, it's time to update your documents.

Think carefully about who you trust to make important decisions if you're unable to make them yourself.

Review Joint Accounts and Shared Services

Even after separation, many couples discover they still share financial arrangements.

Take time to review:

Joint bank accounts.

Credit cards.

Direct debits.

- Utilities

Streaming subscriptions.

Online accounts.

Passwords.

Digital storage.

Mobile phone plans.

Closing these loops helps create a clean financial break.

Don't Forget Your Digital Life

Our financial lives now exist online as much as they do on paper.

Update passwords for:

Banking.

Email.

Investment accounts.

Shopping accounts.

Government services.

Cloud storage.

Taking control of your digital identity is just as important as organising your paperwork.

Vanessa's Conversation Starter

Ask yourself:

"If something happened to me tomorrow, would the right people be making decisions on my behalf?"

If you're unsure, that's your next conversation.

TAKE ACTION

- Update your Will.
- Review your Enduring Power of Attorney.
- Update medical decision-maker documents if applicable.
- Review your superannuation beneficiaries.
- Check all insurance policies.
- Close or separate joint financial accounts where appropriate.
- Change passwords for important online accounts.
- Store your important legal documents somewhere safe and tell a trusted person where they are.

VANESSA'S INSIGHT

Legal documents aren't about expecting the worst.

They're about making life easier for the people you love.

I've met too many families dealing with unnecessary stress because important documents weren't updated after a major life event.

Divorce gives you the opportunity to reset more than your finances.

It gives you the chance to make sure every important document reflects the life you're creating now.

That's one of the greatest gifts you can leave for the people who matter most.

DATING AGAIN - PROTECTING YOUR HEART AND YOUR FINANCES

"Falling in love again is exciting. Just don't leave your financial common sense behind."

After divorce, many people tell me they never want another relationship.

Then life surprises them.

Months or years later, someone new comes along.

A coffee turns into dinner.

Dinner turns into weekends together.

Before long, you're thinking about sharing a home, combining finances or planning a future.

Finding love again is something to celebrate.

But after everything you've been through, it's worth slowing down when it comes to money.

Trust takes time.

So should financial decisions.

Mark's Story

Mark was divorced in his early fifties.

After several years on his own, he met someone who made him laugh again.

They travelled together, spent weekends with each other's families and eventually decided to move in together.

Within six months, they had opened a joint bank account and purchased a new car together.

Neither thought much about what would happen if the relationship didn't last.

Unfortunately, it didn't.

Untangling their finances became almost as stressful as Mark's divorce.

Looking back, he said something many people do.

"I confused emotional commitment with financial commitment."

The two don't always need to happen at the same time.

Love Doesn't Have to Mean Combining Everything

One of the biggest myths about relationships is that true commitment means merging every aspect of your financial life.

For many couples, especially later in life, that simply isn't necessary.

Some couples:

Share household expenses but keep separate bank accounts.

Contribute equally to joint costs.

Maintain individual investments.

Own property separately.

Agree on how major purchases will be made.

There's no one right way.

The important thing is that both people understand and agree on the arrangement.

Have the Awkward Conversations Early

Money conversations are often easier before you've made major commitments.

Talk about:

Spending habits.

Debt.

Children from previous relationships.

Financial goals.

Retirement plans.

Property ownership.

Expectations about supporting family members.

These discussions might feel uncomfortable.

They're far less uncomfortable than discovering major differences years later.

Protecting Your Children

If you have children, particularly adult children, new relationships can raise concerns.

Your children may wonder:

Will my inheritance change?

Is Mum or Dad financially secure?

What happens if they remarry?

Will family assets be protected?

While you don't need to share every financial detail, being open about your intentions can prevent misunderstandings and resentment later.

Consider Getting Advice

If you're bringing significant assets into a new relationship, it's worth seeking legal and financial advice before making major financial commitments.

This isn't about expecting the relationship to fail.

It's about creating clarity while you're both thinking clearly.

Good planning can protect both people.

Keep Your Financial Independence

One of the greatest lessons many people learn after divorce is that financial independence creates confidence.

That doesn't disappear because you've met someone wonderful.

Continue to:

Understand your own finances.

Maintain access to your accounts.

Know where your investments are.

Stay involved in financial decisions.

Healthy relationships are built on partnership, not dependence.

Vanessa's Conversation Starter

Ask yourself:

"Am I making this financial decision because it's right for my future, or because I'm afraid of losing the relationship?"

The answer may tell you everything you need to know.

TAKE ACTION

- Talk openly about money before making major financial commitments.
- Understand each other's financial situation.
- Think carefully before combining finances.
- Seek advice before purchasing property together.
- Review your estate planning if your relationship becomes serious.
- Keep communicating about money as your relationship evolves.

VANESSA'S INSIGHT

One of the joys of life is discovering that happiness can find you again.
I've seen many people build wonderful second relationships after divorce.
The happiest couples aren't those who never talk about money.
They're the ones who talk about it early, honestly and often.
Love deserves optimism.
Your finances deserve careful planning.
The two can absolutely exist together.

REBUILDING YOUR CONFIDENCE - YOUR BEST FINANCIAL YEARS MAY STILL BE AHEAD OF YOU

"Divorce changes your life, but it doesn't define it. One chapter ending doesn't mean your story is over."

There comes a moment after divorce when life begins to feel a little quieter.

The paperwork is finished.

The house has been sold, or you've settled into a new one.

The routine with the children becomes more familiar.

You stop thinking about your divorce every day.

It's often at this point that a new question emerges.

"What do I want my life to look like now?"

It's a wonderful question because, for the first time in a long time, you're no longer just surviving.

You're planning.

Helen's Story

Helen was 57 when her divorce was finalised.

For months, she'd focused on getting through each day.

Once everything was settled, she realised she'd spent so much time thinking about what she'd lost that she'd forgotten to think about what she still wanted.

She always dreamed of travelling.

She wanted to learn Italian.

She hoped to buy a small apartment near the beach one day.

For years, those dreams had been pushed aside.

This time, she wrote them down.

Then she started building a financial plan around them.

None of them happened overnight.

But one by one, they became reality.

Helen often says divorce didn't give her the life she planned.

It gave her the courage to create a different one.

Give Yourself Permission to Dream Again

After divorce, many people become so focused on recovering financially that they stop imagining a future they can enjoy.

Money isn't just about paying bills.

It's about creating choices.

Ask yourself:

Where do I want to live?

What kind of work do I want to do?

How do I want to spend my weekends?

What experiences matter most to me?

What would make me feel financially secure?

These questions are just as important as your budget.

Confidence Comes from Action

Many people believe confidence comes first.

Confidence usually follows action.

Every positive financial decision builds belief.

- Paying off debt
- Growing your savings
- Learning about investing
- Meeting with a financial adviser
- Updating your super

None of these things changes your life overnight.

Together, they change your future.

Invest in Yourself

One of the best investments you can make after divorce isn't always financial.

It might be:

- Learning a new skill
- Returning to study
- Starting a business
- Asking for a promotion
- Building your professional network
- Looking after your health

Your earning capacity is one of your greatest financial assets.

Never underestimate its value.

Stop Comparing Yourself

One of the quickest ways to lose confidence is comparing your life to someone else's.

Perhaps friends are retiring earlier.

Perhaps your former partner appears to have moved on more quickly.

Perhaps someone your age has more money.

None of those comparisons helps you.

The only meaningful comparison is between where you are today and where you were six months ago.

Celebrate your own progress.

Success Looks Different Now

Before divorce, success may have meant a larger house or a higher household income.

Today, it might mean something entirely different.

- Peace
- Freedom
- Sleeping well at night
- Knowing your bills are paid
- Having choices

Those are achievements worth celebrating.

Vanessa's Conversation Starter

Ask yourself:

"If money wasn't something I feared anymore, what would I do differently?"

Write down your answer.

You might be surprised by how much it reveals about the future you want to build.

TAKE ACTION

- Write down three financial goals for the next five years.
- Review your career and earning opportunities.
- Continue building your emergency savings.
- Learn one new thing about money every month.
- Celebrate every financial milestone, no matter how small.
- Make time to enjoy your life as well as rebuild it.

VANESSA'S INSIGHT

One of my favourite conversations is with someone who tells me, "I never thought I'd get here."

Not because they're wealthy.

Because they're happy.

Because they feel in control.

Because they're no longer frightened every time they open their banking app.

Financial confidence doesn't arrive all at once.

It grows through hundreds of small decisions that quietly transform your life.

Your divorce may become part of your story.

But it never has to become the headline.

Some of the happiest, strongest and most financially confident people I've met built that confidence after one of the hardest experiences of their lives.

There's no reason you can't be one of them.

YOUR NEXT CHAPTER - BUILDING A LIFE THAT'S TRULY YOURS

"The end of a marriage is not the end of your future. Sometimes it's the beginning of a life you haven't yet imagined."

If you've read this far, you've already done something important.

You've chosen to prepare.

You've chosen to learn.

Most importantly, you've chosen to believe that your financial future is worth protecting.

That matters.

Because divorce has a way of making us focus on what we've lost.

- The relationship
- The home
- The plans you made together
- The future you expected

Those losses are real, and they deserve to be acknowledged.

But there comes a time when your attention needs to shift from looking backwards to looking forwards.

Not because the past doesn't matter.

But because your future deserves just as much care.

Michael's Story

Michael was 61 when his marriage ended.

He thought his best years were behind him.

He worried he'd never recover financially and that retirement would now be impossible.

For months, he focused on everything that had gone wrong.

Then one day, a friend asked him a simple question.

"What do you want the next ten years to look like?"

No one had asked him that before.

Instead of thinking about what he'd lost, Michael started thinking about what he still wanted.

- He reduced his debt
- He adjusted his retirement plans

- He took on consulting work he genuinely enjoyed
- He travelled more than he ever had during his marriage

Several years later, Michael told me something I'll never forget.

"My life isn't the one I planned. But it's still a life I love."

Your Definition of Success May Have Changed

Before your divorce, success may have looked like:

- A family home
- Joint financial goals
- Retirement together
- Building wealth as a couple

Today, success may mean something very different.

It may mean:

- Feeling financially secure
- Living within your means
- Sleeping well at night
- Having meaningful relationships
- Spending time with your children and grandchildren
- Looking forward instead of backwards

None of those goals are smaller.

They're simply different.

Keep Having Money Conversations

One of the reasons I wrote this guide is because difficult money conversations don't end when your divorce is final.

You'll still have conversations about:

- Retirement
- Helping adult children
- Dating again
- Caring for ageing parents
- Estate planning
- Your own future

The more comfortable you become talking about money, the more confident you'll become making financial decisions.

Conversations create clarity.

And clarity creates confidence.

Your Future Doesn't Need to Be Perfect

You don't need to earn more than your former partner.

You don't need the biggest investment portfolio.

You don't need to "catch up" with anyone else.

You simply need a financial life that supports the life you want to live.

That's success.

What Will Your Next Chapter Look Like?

Take a few moments to think about the future.

What do you want more of?

- Freedom?
- Adventure?

Peace?

- Security?
- Time?
- Connection?

Write down three things you want your next chapter to include.

Keep them somewhere you'll see them regularly.

They're no longer just dreams.

They're the beginning of a plan.

Vanessa's Conversation Starter

Ask yourself:

"Five years from now, what do I hope I'll thank myself for doing today?"

Then take the first step.

It doesn't need to be a big one.

It just needs to move you forward.

TAKE ACTION

- Write down three goals for the next five years.
- Review this guide every six months as your circumstances change.
- Keep learning about money.
- Ask for help when you need it.
- Celebrate how far you've already come.
- Remember that rebuilding takes time.

VANESSA'S INSIGHT

Some of the strongest people I've met are those who never expected to start again.

Yet they did.

Not because they wanted to.

Because life asked them to.

And step by step, conversation by conversation, decision by decision, they built a future they were proud of.

You can too.

A PERSONAL NOTE FROM ME

If you've made it to the end of this guide, thank you for spending this time with me.

There is one final thing I'd like to share.

I've been through divorce myself.

So when I say I understand how overwhelming it can feel, I don't say that as someone looking in from the outside. I say it as someone who has lived it.

There were moments when I wondered what my future would look like. Moments when the financial decisions felt heavy, and the emotional ones felt even heavier.

What I learned is that healing doesn't happen on a timetable.

There is no prize for recovering the fastest.

Give yourself permission to grieve what you've lost.

Give yourself time to recover.

Be patient with yourself on the days that feel harder than others.

And remember that rebuilding your financial life isn't just about numbers - it's about rebuilding your confidence, your independence and your belief in what's possible.

If this guide has taught you anything, I hope it's this:

You don't have to have every answer today.

You don't have to make every decision this week.

You simply need to keep taking the next right step.

- One conversation
- One decision
- One day at a time

I've seen so many people come through divorce stronger, wiser and more financially confident than they ever imagined.

I truly believe you can too.

Thank you for letting me be part of your journey.

All the best,

